

nearly half a minute while red lights beep and a faint shaking is felt—a sign that the cube is rotating.

Any attempt to open a door currently underwater causes the cube to move in this way, putting the face the characters are trying to exit onto above the surface, and preventing water from pouring in when the door is opened. Many of the seemingly random rotations of the cube are caused by creatures traveling between faces in this way.

If one group of characters goes inside a junction room and travels to a new face while other characters are on the surface, those characters outside need to deal with the cube's movement (see "When the Cube Rolls"). If different groups of characters or NPCs try to operate different underwater doors at the same time, an alarm blares and the cube doesn't move. Likewise, if a face about to go underwater has a door opened on it, the cube temporarily ceases its movement and alarms go off. The skull lord Vargo and other creatures attuned to the Six-Face Throne can override such conflicts to open and close any door they choose and orient the cube accordingly—even to the extent of forcing doors to close on lawful creatures.

Characters who step out through a door that has just emerged above the water see that face of the island covered with wet, unpixelated bodies just emerged from the sea (unless they're on face 5 and the balhannoth is alive). If the face of the cube they left most recently was also unpixelated, characters might assume that they've returned to that face, with no visible landmarks except hills of bodies, the drow ship in the distance, and the sea stretching to the horizon.

INTERIOR DOORS AND GRAVITY SWITCHES

Several exterior doors lead deeper into the interior of the cube, as noted in their descriptions. These entrances are notable for having a second door, identical to the exterior door, 40 feet along the shaft. The double doors are an extra level of defense to protect the cube's vital interior. They can be opened like the exterior doors, and regenerate in the same way if damaged or destroyed.

Beyond each interior door, the 20-foot-wide shaft continues on into the depths of Cube 1717. However, beyond the 40-foot point marking the interior door, the local gravity of the nearest face is canceled out by the gravity of face 6. Characters moving down these shafts feel the strange sensation of gravity swiftly changing, so that a character climbing down a ladder on a wall will suddenly be crawling backward along a floor. Once they adjust to the new gravity, characters can stand and walk in the shaft as they explore the interior of the cube.

Characters in the interior under face 6 who move toward many of the doors on other faces have the reverse experience. Over the space of a few steps, it suddenly becomes harder and harder to walk forward, until the characters must crouch down and climb along the ladder as the floor becomes a wall.

These shifts in gravity are disorienting but harmless. However, two places in the cube transform this gravity switch into a potentially deadly trap. All the inhabitants

of the cube know about these areas and how to safely move through them. See area 4.3 and area 5.2 for more information.

FEATURES OF THE CUBE

All the interior spaces of the cube are pixelated except for areas 6.17 and 6.18 (Avnas's rooms), area 6.22 (the surgery), area 6.23 (the laboratory), area 6.29 (the library), area 6.31 (Vargo's chamber), and area 6.38 (the temple of Tiamat). The characters might be able to see unpixelated versions of other rooms, either by using *pixel glasses* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix), or by using *dispel magic*, *remove curse*, or Styx water to temporarily unpixelate part of the room.

Before it was pixelated, the interior of the cube had an austere, fortress-like look, punctuated by ornate devilish imagery. Pixelation has simplified that look to an even harsher, more barren appearance. Unless otherwise specified, all interior corridors and rooms are dimly lit by white or red pixel panels, set into the walls at 30-foot intervals. The main corridors and shafts running between rooms are 20 feet wide, while some smaller corridors are 10 feet wide. Most corridors are perfectly square or rectangular, while the shafts are circular with pixelated edges. The risk of gravitational shifts means that corridors and rooms feature emergency ladders or rungs set into grooves running along floors, ceilings, and walls.

Noisy Passage. Unless the characters take care to use stealth, any movement through the cube sets footsteps echoing loudly off its iron floors and walls, alerting creatures in adjacent rooms. Likewise, the characters receive advance warning of any nonstealthy creatures approaching.

Damage and Destruction. Many parts of the cube's interior (particularly areas 6.14, 6.32, and 6.39) retain damage from the battle with the yugoloths that sent the cube to the Material Plane. Some rooms have been completely destroyed and are inaccessible, but characters who return to these damaged places over the course of a few hours notice that the metal in those areas is slowly regenerating. If the Heart Engine (see area 6.28) remains active, the cube completely heals itself in time, and the damaged rooms reappear.

FACE 1: EXHAUST PORT

This face is the bottom of the ship in its normal orientation, with face 6 on the top. It is the only face that has no doors leading to junction rooms and other faces. Instead, the only way in or out of the face is its central shaft.

When the characters first survey face 1, they see gray steam rising from a crater in the distance, mixing with the fog as strange chemical compounds evaporate from the pool at area 1.1.

AREA 1.1: CENTRAL SHAFT

Within a rough-walled crater rising at the center of face 1, a 40-foot-wide circular shaft drops 30 feet into a pool of murky, steaming water. An oily substance clings to the pool's surface in glinting squares, like fish scales.

The sides of the shaft resemble blackened iron and are slick, such that climbing up or down without using a rope requires a successful DC 20 Strength (Athletics) check. A character who tests or enters the murky black water finds it the temperature of a warm bath, and notes that it smells like cassia (or cinnamon), oil, and tar. The oily substance is pixelated, and crystallizes in pixel-like masses on the skin and clothes of characters in the water. These encrustations are harmless and can be brushed off. (The water was originally from the Styx sea, but the exceptionally powerful pixelating curse within the shaft has dispelled its powers and turned it into normal water.)

Exhaust Port Pool. A character who tries to swim to the bottom of the black pool feels a strange dizzying sensation when they are 10 feet under the surface. If they continue to dive, they pass through a layer of floating debris—most of it pixelated body parts—then find themselves suddenly swimming upward. Characters emerge from the other side of the pool at the bottom of area 6.47—a slimy, air-filled, 200-foot-long shaft dimly lit by red lights high above.

Passing through the pool this way involves a gravity flip into the dominant gravity of face 6, so that the character's former 'up' is now 'down.' The full depth of the pool is 20 feet—10 feet on either side of the debris wall that marks where the gravity switches. A magical pressure barrier beneath face 6 keeps water from entering the cube this way when face 1 is submerged.

This shaft is the exhaust port for Cube 1717. Every hour on the hour, the cube expels garbage and bodies through the shaft, dropping it from area 6.47 and then forcing it out of area 1.1 in an explosive geyser of cubic debris. During the characters' first time on face 1, roll a d6 every 10 minutes. On a 1, the cube shoots up a geyser, spraying the area around area 1.1 with piles of pixelated dead. The same geyser then erupts every hour thereafter.

AREA 1.2: JUVENILE CORPSE FLOWERS

A mat of strange, fleshy green plants with purple buds, each about six inches high, grows here upon the mosaic-like 'rock' of the island. The plants completely cover the surface down to the cube's edge, where they disappear

under the water. The plants are unpixelated, and have a smell like rotten flesh.

The mat of vegetation is a mass of immature corpse flowers (from *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*), growing from the main mass at area 4.5. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (Nature or Arcana) check identifies these plant creatures. Immune to the Styx sea, the corpse flowers are growing rapidly, though this patch is harmless. A character who uproots a portion of the patch sees it is growing from the bodies underneath. The Styx water traveling through the plants' roots unpixelates the bodies on the surface, which blend seamlessly into the cubical, pixelated bodies outside the roots' range.

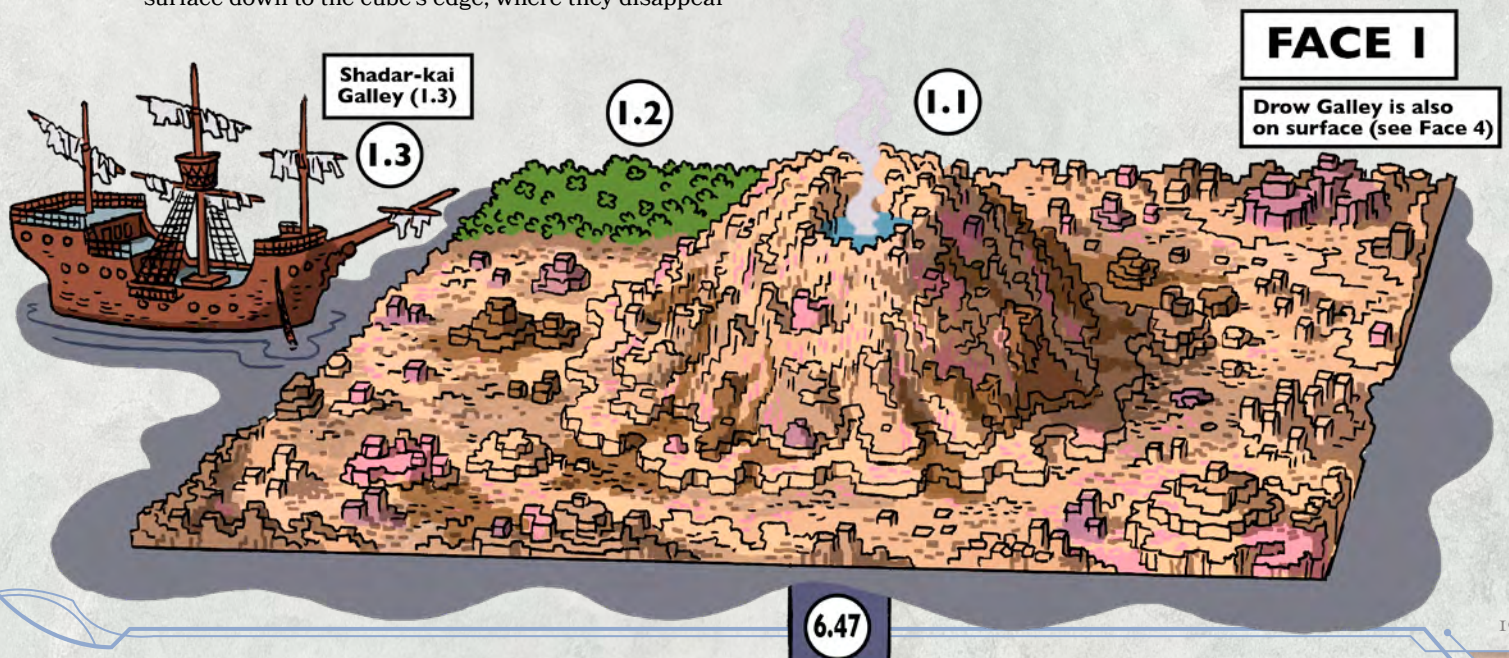
AREA 1.3: SHADAR-KAI CARAVEL

When face 1 is up, a strange ship floats on the waves 50 feet from the edge of the island. This caravel is gray and white, and decorated with white carvings of autumn leaves. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (History) check identifies the style as suggestive of the mysterious shadar-kai. The ship is badly battered, its sails are missing, and it floats low on the waterline. Its anchor is dropped (and stuck in face 2).

The interior of the caravel is thoroughly wet but still relatively intact. Anything of value on board has been ruined, though, and the ship's cargo hold is partly flooded with the water of the Styx sea. Whenever a face of the cube other than 1 or 2 rises to the surface, the shadar-kai caravel is dragged down beneath the water. Though the ship sinks a little more each time, it still maintains partial buoyancy from the air trapped within its cabins.

Sole Survivor. Any characters searching the ship for valuables or survivors find relatively recent footprints along the wet floor. These lead to a locked storage closet in the stern. The locked door can be picked with a successful DC 16 Dexterity check using thieves' tools, or smashed open with a successful DC 13 Strength check.

Hiding in the storage closet is Fern, a frightened and wary survivor of the shadar-kai expedition. Fern is a **shadar-kai shadow dancer** with the following changes:





SHADAR-KAI
SHADOW
DANCER

- Her Intelligence is 14.
- She wears a *cap of water breathing*.
- She wields a +1 *spiked chain*.

Fern is able to leave the galley and search the island when face 2 is up and the caravel is beached (see that section for more information). However, she has not figured out how to open the cube's doors. When the characters meet her, she is suffering only 1 physical level of the pixelating curse, since she is cured of it (and loses her memories of having been pixelated before) whenever the cube rolls and the caravel is resubmerged.

The closet contains all the valuable items Fern could scavenge from the ship: two *potions of healing* and a week's worth of soggy food and fresh water.

Fractured Memories. Fern and her crewmates—led by a shadar-kai elder—received a message from the Raven Queen that the walls of life and death had been breached, and that the dead had escaped. They journeyed to the island in an attempt to discover the nature of the breach and try to close it. But their mission turned to disaster when all except Fern were killed by the hydrolaths and the vampiric mists. Fern escaped by fleeing back to the ship and hiding. But a few hours later, the cube flipped

to send the caravel under the water with its anchor firmly stuck to the submerged side. Fern's *cap of water breathing* allowed her to survive the immersion, but did nothing to deter the Styx sea's memory-wiping effects.

Exposure to Styx water has created huge gaps in Fern's memory, including everything that has happened since she first sighted the island. She doesn't remember where she came from or what else the Raven Queen told the shadar-kai. She warns the characters that there are dangerous creatures in the water that ate her friends.

Additionally, if the characters befriend her, Fern shares one more memory so powerful that even the Styx sea can't erase it: she volunteered for the shadar-kai mission because she dreamed that her dead friend Astilbe was on the island and could be rescued. (Astilbe was one of the reborn souls doomed to fight on Acheron, but was converted into a pixelated creature and is now one of the skull lord's guards at area 6.31.) Fern will join the characters if they promise to help her search for Astilbe.

FACE 2: ANCHOR POINT

The most notable feature of this face is the shadar-kai caravel (area 2.3) resting on its side, attached by its anchor chain and guarded by an unexpected defender. A number of metallic cubic 'rocks' are also scattered across the face, growing thickest in area 2.5.

AREA 2.1: JUNCTION ROOM

A door at this location leads to a two-way junction room, then beyond to area 4.1.

AREA 2.2: JUNCTION ROOM

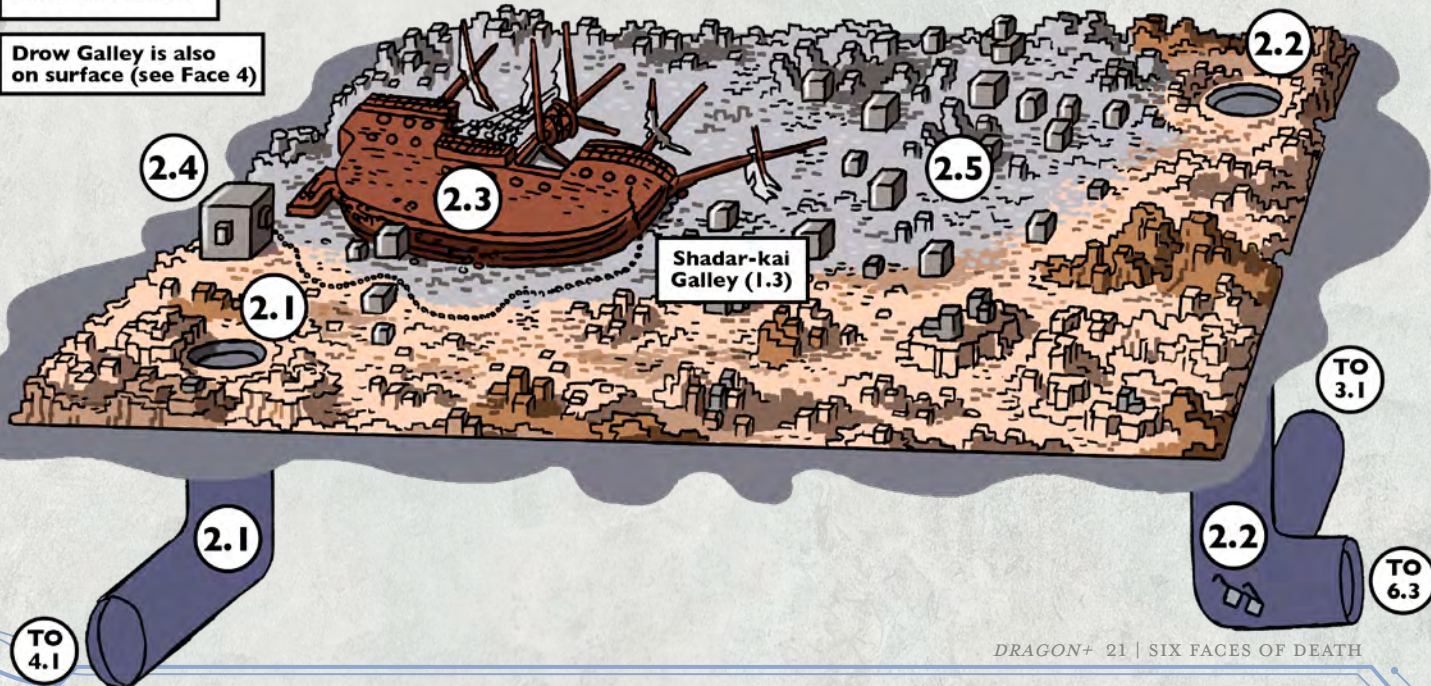
This door leads to a three-way junction room whose shafts lead on to area 3.1 and area 6.3. A set of *pixel glasses* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix) lie at the bottom of this shaft.

AREA 2.3: SHADAR-KAI CARAVEL

The foundering shadar-kai ship is described at area 1.3, but characters who see it on this face will come to

FACE 2

Drow Galley is also on surface (see Face 4)



understand how the shadar-kai accidentally anchored the ship too well. When the cube rolls and face 2 comes up, the shadar-kai caravel is pulled out of the water to end up lying on its side, as if thrown there by a giant. Its stout iron anchor chain, 100 feet long, leads away from the ship to area 2.4.

Like everything else on the island, the caravel is vulnerable to the pixelating curse. If face 2 is above the water when the characters first come to the island, the wood of the ship has already started to transform into brown cubes. Within four hours, the caravel is entirely pixelated, though it is still recognizable as a ship.

AREA 2.4: ANCHOR

When the shadar-kai caravel dropped its anchor, it was caught by the gravitational pull of face 2 and thoroughly embedded in the face's iron surface. That spot is now guarded by a confused gnomish construct called a **stone defender** (see *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*). Normally called upon as a bodyguard, the stone defender has decided that it guards the anchor, and it attacks anyone who approaches this area.

If face 2 has been out of the water for more than a few hours, the stone defender takes on the form of a human-sized gray cubical rock next to where the pixelated anchor is embedded. If anyone approaches, the construct attacks with surprise, with its False Appearance making its pixelated body blend into the pixelated landscape. If face 2 has just emerged from the water, the stone defender is in its true form of a stout, humanoid robot with stone plates bolted into its metal frame.

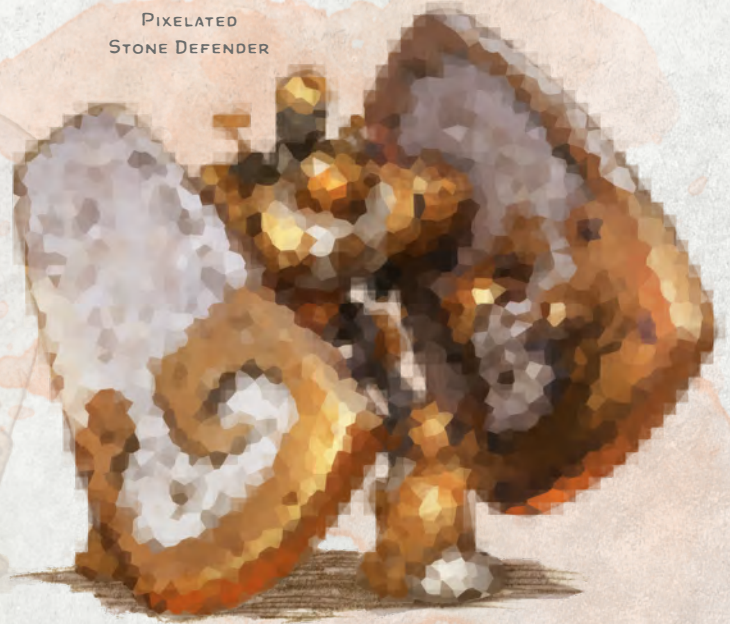
The stone defender normally defends the anchor until destroyed, but it can be tricked into guarding another item instead if the characters present one. Destroying the defender, getting it to guard another item, or cutting the anchor chain frees the shadar-kai caravel, which floats up freely (though it remains damaged and in need of serious repairs) the next time the cube rolls.

AREA 2.5: CLOCKWORK CONGREGATION

This section of the face is covered with metallic objects, all of them the remnants of clockworks created by Avnas. When the cube is pixelated, this area takes the form of an unusually large number of shining gray-and-brown metallic blocks, which continue over the edge to face 3. Some of the blocks make a ticking sound, or crawl and hop around.

When the cube isn't pixelated, the broken constructs can be seen in their real forms as strange bronze and iron devices, scattered among the dead bodies. Though

PIXELATED
STONE DEFENDER



most of them are destroyed, a few still twitch, flip, or crawl in circles like malfunctioning toys.

Amid the harmless mass of barely functional clockwork devices, a number of constructs are potential threats. Each time the characters approach this area, or each 10 minutes they spend here, roll a d6 to determine what they encounter. All these creatures can be found in *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*. You might wish to use the Clockwork Malfunctions table in that book to give personality to these damaged constructs.

d6 Construct Encounter

1–2	2d4 bronze scouts
3	1 oaken bolter
4	1d2 iron cobras
5	1 stone defender
6	1d4 duergar screamers

Bronze Scouts. When encountered, these bronze scouts are in the process of pushing the dead around the face of the cube. They crawl toward any creatures they can see or hear to assess them, but lose interest in living creatures and depart the following round if they are ignored. If attacked, the bronze scouts fight until destroyed.

Oaken Bolter. This war machine immediately begins firing at any creature that moves within its field of view. Its vision and memory are poor, though, so if any creatures hide or stand perfectly still for 2 rounds, it ignores them and rolls away.

Iron Cobras. Any iron cobras the characters stumble upon are hiding, aided by their impressive Dexterity (Stealth) checks and the advantage they gain on those checks if the face is pixelated. If an iron cobra takes any damage, it flees and hides.

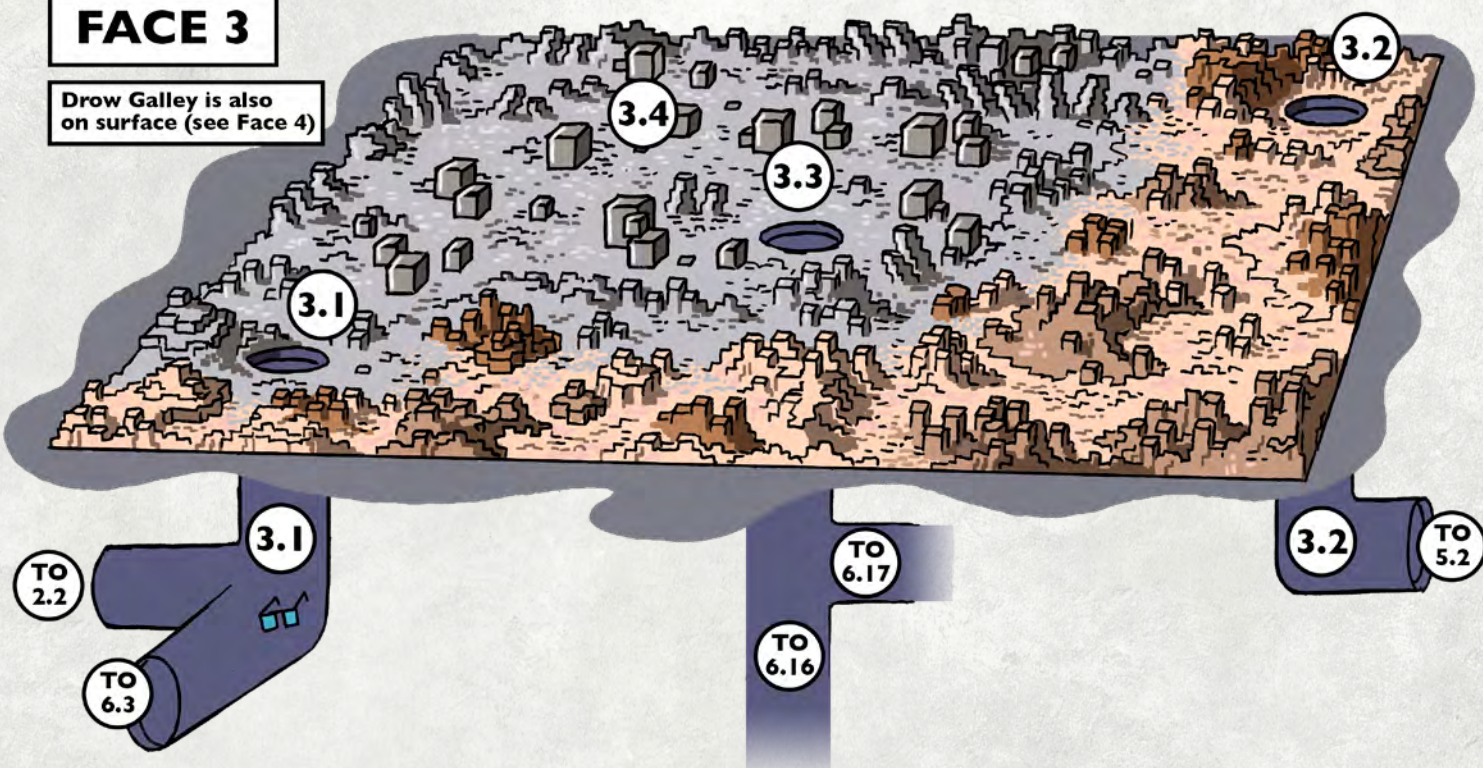
Stone Defender. The stone defender has picked a spot or a random object to guard, gesturing threateningly at any creature that comes close, and attacking if any creature comes within 5 feet. If left alone, the construct forgets about the spot or object it defends, then wanders off and repeats the process.

PIXELATED BRONZE SCOUT



FACE 3

Drow Galley is also on surface (see Face 4)



Duergar Screamer. With their shrill, terrifying voices, these constructs are heard before they are seen. They hunt and fight all non-duergar humanoids until destroyed.

FACE 3: JUNKYARD

Face 3 appears as a wasteland of rock or bodies, depending on its pixelated state. It has few notable features except the large number of metallic blocks and cubes that spread across its surface.

AREA 3.1: JUNCTION ROOM

This door leads to a three-way junction room whose shafts lead on to area 2.2 and area 6.3. A pair of *pixel glasses* (see the “New Magic Items” appendix) lie at the bottom of this shaft.

AREA 3.2: JUNCTION ROOM

A door at this location leads to a two-way junction room, then beyond to area 5.2.

AREA 3.3: INTERIOR DOOR AND GRAVITY SWITCH

The exterior door here opens to reveal an interior door 40 feet beyond. Past the interior door, gravity suddenly shifts to the orientation of face 6, and a short corridor leads to the junction space between areas 6.16 and 6.17.

AREA 3.4: CLOCKWORK CONGREGATION

This area of metallic cubes is identical to area 2.5, and has the same random construct encounters.

FACE 4: GARDEN OF THE DEAD

Face 4 is a wasteland of rock or bodies, depending on its pixelated state. Its dominant feature is the enormous green mass of juvenile corpse flowers that spreads across area 4.5.

AREA 4.1: JUNCTION ROOM

This door leads to a two-way junction room and area 2.1 beyond. Anyone who emerges from or approaches this door draws the attention of the corpse flower at area 4.5.

AREA 4.2: SPECIAL JUNCTION ROOM

An interior door opens up 40 feet beyond the exterior door. Halfway between the exterior and interior doors, gravity suddenly shifts to the orientation of face 6. Beyond the interior door is area 6.33A.

AREA 4.3: INTERIOR DOOR AND GRAVITY SWITCH

The exterior door here opens to reveal an interior door 40 feet beyond. Past the interior door, gravity suddenly shifts to the orientation of face 6, and a short corridor leads to the junction space between area 6.1 and area 6.8.

Any creature moving toward this area through level 6 simply climbs along a ladder, passing the ‘horizontal’ ladder shaft to area 4.3 as they do. However, creatures descending from area 4.3 must carefully navigate a change in the cube’s internal gravity.

Deadly Gravity. From the perspective of those coming from area 4.3, the shaft abruptly opens up in what appears to be the ceiling of a two-way corridor. Two of the four ladders leading down curve and run along the ceiling of this corridor, while the other two go halfway down the wall of the corridor before turning 90 degrees to the left and right. Looking down into the corridor, the characters see that the T corridor ends in another circular metal door (area 6.1) in one direction. In the other direction, the corridor continues 60 feet before widening out into a strange room filled with blocky furniture (area 6.8). With a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check, a character notices that the furniture in area 6.8 appears to be on the wall, while the floor is bare except for a few glowing lights.